However, the electoral commission has cited two related laws in justification of its decisions: one barring people from running for office if their parents were not Myanmar citizens at the time of their birth; and another requiring candidates to have lived in the country for the past ten consecutive years.[20]

Of course, the NLD's protests would carry more weight if Aung San Suu Kyi could bring herself to speak out. Even in late June 2015, she was still ducking this issue, arguing that 'the protection of rights of minorities is an issue which should be addressed very, very carefully and as quickly and effectively as possible, and I'm not sure the government is doing enough about it'.[21] In some ways, that may count as progress, given her previous statements, but it treats the situation of the Rohingyas as if it were a technical academic exercise, a problem of the same type as that created by their exclusion from the designated list of ethnic groups in the 1947 Constitution. Furthermore, the electoral commission is not just removing Rohingyas from the list but any Muslim candidates regardless of their ethnicity. The 2015 elections were unique in Burma's post-colonial history. For the first time, there were no Rohingya candidates and no Rohingya members of parliament, and very few Muslims from other ethnic groups. Even under the worst of the military rule this did not happen.

The forced displacement of the Rohingyas into internal camps, and the removal of their last vestige of democratic rights[22] has led some observers to call Myanmar an 'apartheid state'.[23] In consequence, the Rohingyas are now excluded both as electors and in terms of representation[24] and they are an easy (and shared) target for all the represented political camps. The implication is clear: failure to gain any political voice to speak for their interests in the 2015 elections means that, as a Rohingya activist put it, 'the whole Rohingya will be a sort of degraded or persecuted community, and that cannot continue for long'.[25] The inevitable result is that 'the Rohingyas will disappear from Rakhine State. It is sure Rohingya will disappear'.[26]

2015 elections: wider issues

In terms of electoral politics, the NLD also faces significant challenges even after its 2015 victory. It needs to retain support among the Burman ethnic majority and this carries a price in terms of the policies it can put